Resilient Villages Zimbabwe

Prevention of Sexual Exploitation, Abuse and Harassment (PSEAH) Policy

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1. Purpose & Core Values

Resilient Villages Zimbabwe (RVZ) is strictly committed to upholding the inherent dignity, human rights, and well-being of all individuals, particularly the vulnerable populations and communities we serve. RVZ recognizes that positions of trust must never be misused to exploit, abuse, or harass others.

The purpose of this Policy is to:

- Guarantee a safe, respectful, and zero-tolerance environment across all operational spaces, offices, and community field locations.
- Establish clear, transparent mechanisms for preventative measures, confidential reporting, and robust survivor-centred investigations.
- Uphold institutional accountability in alignment with international safeguarding frameworks and national legal statutes.

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2. Scope & Responsibilities

This Policy applies universally to all **RVZ Representatives**, defined comprehensively as:

- Permanent, temporary, contract, and casual employees.
- Members of the Board of Directors and governance bodies.
- Interns, volunteers, fellows, and seconded staff.
- Consultants, individual contractors, service providers, suppliers, and commercial vendors.
- Visitors, media personnel, and official delegations accompanying RVZ operations.
- Downstream partner organizations, sub-recipients, and sub-grantees.

Institutional Oversight:
Governance oversight of this Policy rests with the Board of Directors. Operational administration, enforcement, and daily management are delegated to the Executive Director.

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3. Comprehensive Definitions & Standards

To ensure complete clarity across all institutional activities, the following definitions and standard classifications apply under this Policy:

Term	Definition & Scope
RVZ Representative	Any individual officially affiliated with, employed by, or representing RVZ in any capacity, whether paid or unpaid.
Beneficiary	Any individual or group receiving support, services, resources, or engaging with programs facilitated by RVZ.
SEAH	An overarching acronym referring collectively to Sexual Exploitation, Sexual Abuse, and Sexual Harassment.
Sexual Exploitation	Any actual or attempted abuse of a position of vulnerability, differential power, or trust for sexual purposes, including, but not limited to, profiting monetarily, socially, or politically from the sexual exploitation of another.
Sexual Abuse	The actual or threatened physical intrusion of a sexual nature, whether by force or under unequal or coercive conditions.
Sexual Harassment	Any unwelcome sexual advance, request for sexual favors, or other verbal, non-verbal, or physical conduct of a sexual nature that creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive working environment.

Term	Definition & Scope
Child Sexual Abuse & Exploitation	Any sexual activity with a child (defined as any human being below 18 years of age), regardless of local legal age of consent or perceived age.
Online Child Sexual Exploitation	The use of information and communication technology to facilitate sexual abuse or exploitation of a child, including grooming, sharing images, or live streaming.
Child	Any individual under the age of 18 years.
Vulnerable Adult	Any individual aged 18 or older who is or may be unable to take care of themselves or protect themselves against significant harm or exploitation due to age, disability, displacement, or socio-economic distress.
Survivor	An individual who has been subjected to sexual exploitation, abuse, or harassment.

Detailed Behavioral List: Sexual Harassment Categories

Sexual Harassment includes, but is not limited to, the following specific behaviors:

- **Verbal:** Inappropriate comments about body or clothing, sexual jokes, unsolicited romantic propositions, intrusive questions regarding personal sex life, demands for sexual favors tied to employment/advancement.
- **Non-Verbal:** Lewd gestures, staring or ogling, displaying sexually explicit materials, posters, or digital screens.
- **Physical:** Unwanted physical contact, including touching, pinching, patting, hugging, cornering, or physical assault.
- **Digital/Cyber:** Sending unwelcome sexual messages, emails, media, or engaging in cyber-stalking.

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4. Policy Principles

RVZ anchors its PSEAH operational frameworks on international best practices and human rights standards:

1. **Alignment with International Human Rights Instruments:** This Policy strictly aligns with the Principles of the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC), the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW), and the International Bill of Human Rights.
2. **Prioritizing Safeguarding:** Protection of children and vulnerable adults is an essential prerequisite for all operational design, field deployments, and strategic initiatives.
3. **Zero Tolerance:** RVZ maintains an absolute zero-tolerance policy towards any act of SEAH committed by its staff or associated representatives.
4. **Proactive Prevention:** RVZ commits to continuous risk assessments, capacity-building, community sensitization, and standard-setting to mitigate SEAH risks before they occur.

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5. Mandatory & Prohibited Conduct Code

5.1 Mandatory Standards of Professional Conduct

All RVZ Representatives must:

- Maintain the highest standards of personal and professional integrity.
- Promote an environment free from violence, exploitation, abuse, and harassment.
- Immediately report any suspected or witnessed violations of this Policy through designated safe channels.

5.2 Strict Prohibitions

The following actions are strictly prohibited and constitute grounds for immediate disciplinary action and potential summary dismissal:

- **Transactional Sex:** Exchanging money, employment, goods, assistance, or services for sexual favors or sexual activity.
- **Abuse of Authority:** Utilizing organizational status, power, or operational influence to solicit sexual favors or intimidate beneficiaries or staff.
- **Sexual Activity with Minors:** Engaging in any sexual activity with anyone under 18 years of age, regardless of local age of consent. Mistake of age is not a valid defense.
- **Technological Exploitation:** Capturing, storing, transmitting, or displaying sexually explicit images or media using RVZ equipment or network infrastructure.
- **Procurement:** Facilitating, organizing, or procuring commercial sex workers or sexual services during working hours, official travel, or within RVZ premises.

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6. Governance & Administration Protocols

6.1 Breach of Policy & Sanctions

- **Gross Misconduct:** Any breach of this Policy is treated as gross professional misconduct.
- **Disciplinary Action:** Violations will lead to disciplinary proceedings, up to and including immediate summary dismissal and termination of commercial contracts.
- **Legal Referral:** Criminal conduct will be formally referred to the Zimbabwe Republic Police (ZRP) and relevant legal authorities.
- **Administrative Suspension:** Staff under investigation for SEAH violations may be placed on administrative suspension pending the outcome of internal proceedings.

6.2 Managerial & Staff Responsibilities

- **Managers and Supervisors** are responsible for creating safe operational environments, identifying structural risks, responding immediately to concerns, and ensuring staff undertake mandatory PSEAH training.
- **All Staff Members** must actively participate in training, adhere to behavioral codes, and report any observed or reported breaches without delay.

6.3 Safer Recruitment & Vetting Standards

To prevent perpetrators from joining RVZ, human resources must enforce strict vetting protocols:

- **Reference Verification:** Mandatory verbal and written referee checks specifically inquiring about past policy breaches or allegations concerning sexual misconduct.
- **Background Checks:** Mandatory police criminal record clearances for all prospective personnel.
- **Contractual Commitments:** PSEAH compliance clauses embedded directly into employment contracts, volunteer agreements, and commercial supplier terms.

6.4 Reporting & Survivor-Centred Investigation Protocols

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None
[Incident Occurs or Disclosed]
       |
       ▼
[Report Submitted via Confidential Channels (Line Manager / COO / CEO)]
       |
       ▼
[Immediate Safety & Medical/Psychosocial Support Provided to Survivor]
       |
```

```
      ▼
[Formal Assessment & Formal Investigation Team Convened]
      |
      ▼
[Findings Submitted & Disciplinary/Legal Action Enforced]
```

- **Confidentiality:** Reports will be handled with strict confidentiality, revealing information only on a need-to-know basis.
- **Escalation Pathway:** Concerns may be reported directly to line managers, the Head of HR, the Chief Operating Officer, or the Executive Director. Reports involving executive leadership can be escalated directly to the Board Chairperson.
- **Survivor-Centred Approach:** Investigations must prioritize the safety, dignity, rights, and choices of the survivor. Essential medical, psychosocial, and security support must be facilitated immediately.
- **Natural Justice & Child Participation:** Due process and natural justice apply to all parties. Where children are involved, child-friendly safeguarding procedures and specialized child protection experts must guide participation.
- **Updates:** Survivors and informants will be routinely updated on procedural progress, respecting confidentiality.

6.5 Whistleblower Protection & Malicious Reporting Rules

- **Whistleblower Protection:** No individual who reports a genuine concern in good faith will suffer retaliation, harassment, or administrative detriment.
- **Malicious Reporting:** False or malicious allegations made intentionally to harm an individual will be treated as serious misconduct subject to disciplinary action.

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7. Formal Approval & Authorization

This Prevention of Sexual Exploitation, Abuse and Harassment (PSEAH) Policy has been formally reviewed, approved, and enacted by the Board of Directors and Executive Leadership of Resilient Villages Zimbabwe.

Authorized Signatory	Name & Designation	Signature	Date
Board Governance Approval	Sr Stellar Gaihai Khumalo*Board Chairperson*	_____	Date

Authorized Signatory	Name & Designation	Signature	Date
Executive Management Approval	Jerald Ndungwani*Executive Director*	_____	Date

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8. Appendix: Employee & Associate Acknowledgement Form

Employee & Associate PSEAH Binding Agreement Form

I, _____, confirm that I have received, read, understood, and agreed to abide by the Resilient Villages Zimbabwe (RVZ) **Prevention of Sexual Exploitation, Abuse and Harassment (PSEAH) Policy**.

I understand that adherence to this Policy is a strict condition of my employment, engagement, or partnership with RVZ. I acknowledge that any breach of the mandatory terms, conduct prohibitions, or reporting obligations outlined in this policy may lead to disciplinary action, termination of contract, and potential legal prosecution by civil authorities.

Field	Detail
Full Name of Signatory	_____
National Identity / Passport No.	_____
Position / Title	_____
Department / Partner Entity	_____
Duty Station / Location	Place
Signature	_____
Date	Date

This executed acknowledgement must be returned to the RVZ Human Resources Department upon signing and will be permanently retained in the individual's personnel or institutional file.